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By Faith Alone

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CHAPTER 1

Whatever Happened to Sola Fide?

The idea at the heart of this experiment was always rather simple. If Coca-Cola can sell its drinks, if Lexus can market its cars, why can't the church, using the same principles and very same techniques, market its message? And so it was that the seeker-sensitive church emerged, reconfigured around the consumer, edges softened by marketing wisdom, pastors driven by business savvy, selling the benefits of the gospel while most of the costs were hidden.

Sometimes what was peddled was a gospel entirely without cost — a gospel whose grace is therefore so very cheap. The evangelical church is now, as a direct consequence, a shadow of its former self, no longer able to address culture as it once did. Something vital has been surrendered.

CHAPTER 2

What Did Saint Paul Really Say?

It is a mark of our times that the language of sola fide has become quaint, sometimes incomprehensible, but mostly irrelevant. What once carried the full freight of reformational understanding today seems like an inconsequential matter of interest only to those with a prickly doctrinal sensibility. And yet the contributors to this volume are united by one conviction: the doctrine of justification by faith alone, as recovered by the Protestant Reformers, remains the teaching of Scripture and the only ground of a sinner's acceptance before God.

To blur it, revise it, or set it aside is a departure from the gospel itself.